

▲ ANAND BHADAURIYA, *46*

| SP | *Dhaurahra, UP*

One of Akhilesh Yadav's *navratnas*, associated with him since the satrap started his political journey, this ex-MLC's name was in the SP's first list, with all the kinsfolk. What went viral after his win: an old photograph which has since become a symbol of police brutality—a 2011 party protest in Lucknow where the new MP from Dhaurahra is seen fallen on the road with then DIG D.K. Thakur's shoe pressed to his cheek.





RANJIT DUTTA, *67*

| BJP | *Sonitpur, Assam*

One of the earliest leaders of the BJP in Assam, the ex-state unit chief is a five-time MLA and was a minister in the Sarbananda Sonowal ministry (2016-21).



NAGESH PATIL ASHTIKAR, *52*

| SS (UBT) | *Hingoli, Maharashtra*

A former MLA and a long-time Shiv Sainik who'd stayed true to the Thackerays, Ashtikar won this demographically diverse Marathwada seat—a bastion for the undivided Sena—due to a convergence of Maratha, Muslim and Dalit votes.



K. GOPINATH, *61*

| CONGRESS | *Krishnagiri, Tamil Nadu*

Partymen, disappointed at sitting MP A. Chellakumar being denied the ticket, boycotted him as he went to file his nomination. But the Class 10-pass veteran, a three-time MLA from his native Hosur segment here, had learnt the ups and downs of this hilly Vijayanagara outpost well enough.



◀ TOKHAN SAHU, *54*

| BJP | *Bilaspur, Chhattisgarh*

The only face in the Union cabinet from Chhattisgarh today, the OBC leader climbed up step by step—panch, sarpanch, MLA from Lormi in 2013, and now MP. His predecessor in Bilaspur, state BJP chief Arun Sao, is now MLA from Lormi.

▼ LAXMIKANT PAPPU NISHAD, *54*

| SP | *Sant Kabir Nagar, UP*



The former Menhdawal MLA is another face of the SP's new ingress into non-Yadav OBC segments in eastern UP.

▼ PARIMAL SUKLABAIDYA, *66*

| BJP | *Silchar, Assam*



A five-time MLA and minister with several portfolios, he's known for his clean image.

ANOOP PRADHAN VALMIKI, *47* ▶

| BJP | *Hathras (SC), UP*

Fate plunged him into a crisis right after his victory—with the deadly July 2 stampede in Hathras—so the ex-MLA (from adjacent Khair) who began as a gram pradhan in 2010 will need all his people skills to offer salve to his western UP constituency.





◀ SALENG A. SANGMA, *45*

| CONGRESS | *Tura (ST), Meghalaya*

The four-time MLA was pushed out of the Congress in 2013 by then CM, Mukul Sangma. In 2023, when Mukul left to join the TMC, Saleng did a *ghar wapsi* from the NCP. And got even by defeating Mukul's brother Zenith, as also CM Conrad Sangma's sister Agatha.